11+ Verbal Reasoning

Verbal Reasoning Complete Guide

Syllabus, strategies, and practice for the full 21-question type syllabus

WHAT THIS GUIDE COVERS

The full VR syllabus across all four topic areas, a table of all 21 GL question types with worked examples, eight exam strategies, the most common traps to avoid, word groups to memorise, and a proven revision routine.

FULL SYLLABUS · SHARE WITH FAMILIES Verbal Reasoning · 11+

Contents

01 The Four Topic Areas 3
02 All 21 Question Types with Examples 4
03 Eight Strategies That Save Time 6
04 Common Traps and How to Avoid Them 7
05 Word Groups to Memorise 8
06 How to Build the Habit 9

What Verbal Reasoning Actually Tests

Verbal Reasoning is a test of a child's ability to think logically and solve problems using words, letters, and numbers. It is designed to measure potential rather than school-taught knowledge, which is why preparation needs to cover both vocabulary and pattern-spotting logic equally.

More than half of all marks lost in VR papers come down to vocabulary: a student cannot do the logic of a question because they do not know what one of the words means. This guide addresses both layers: the knowledge layer (vocabulary, word groups, question type recognition) and the method layer (how to work through each question type systematically).

> *"Over 50% of VR errors come from not knowing a word, not from failing the logic. Vocabulary is the foundation everything else is built on."*

01 Verbal Reasoning

The Four Topic Areas

5 min read · Section 01 of 06

VR questions fall into four groups. Each group tests a different combination of vocabulary and logic. Knowing which group a question belongs to tells you immediately what kind of thinking to apply.

A. VOCABULARY AND WORD MEANINGS

This is the most common source of lost marks. If a student does not recognise the words in a question, no amount of logical method will help. Vocabulary breadth is the single most important thing to build before the exam.

| What this group includes

- ***Synonyms and Antonyms:*** Matching words with the same or opposite meanings.
- ***Odd Ones Out:*** Spotting which words in a list do not belong to the same category.
- ***Dual Meanings:*** Identifying words that have more than one meaning (for example, bark as a dog's sound and bark as a tree's skin).
- ***Word Analogies:*** Completing a relationship pair: Foot is to Sock as Hand is to Glove.

B. LETTER MANIPULATION AND CODE BREAKING

These puzzles treat the alphabet like a number line or a substitution cipher. The logic is mathematical, but the inputs are letters. Students who write out the full alphabet at the top of their answer sheet before starting consistently perform better here.

| What this group includes

- ***Alphabet Shifts:*** Moving letters forward or backward in the alphabet by a fixed number of places.
- ***Mirror Codes:*** Swapping letters with their reverse counterpart (A becomes Z, B becomes Y, and so on).
- ***Hidden Words:*** Finding a complete word buried across two adjacent words in a sentence.
- ***Move a Letter:*** Removing one letter from one word and inserting it into another to create two new valid words.

C. LOGIC AND SEQUENTIAL REASONING

These questions require careful, step-by-step thinking. There is always a single correct answer that can be proven from the given information. Students who rush or guess on this question type consistently lose marks that a methodical reader would collect.

| What this group includes

- ***Logical Deduction:*** Solving who-is-where riddles by working through a list of given clues one at a time.
- ***Reading Information:*** Identifying which statement must be true based on a short paragraph of facts.
- ***Letter Series:*** Finding the next pair in an alphabetical sequence such as AB, CD, EF...

D. NUMBERS IN A WORD CONTEXT

These are mathematical puzzles wrapped in a verbal format. The maths itself is straightforward, but students are often caught out by the presentation. BIDMAS (Brackets, Indices, Division and Multiplication, Addition and Subtraction) applies to all of these.

What this group includes

- ***Number Series:*** Finding the pattern in a string of numbers and predicting the next term.
- ***Letters for Numbers:*** Swapping letters for their assigned numerical values to solve an equation.
- ***Related Numbers:*** Finding the missing number in a three-part set based on the relationship between the other two.

The vocabulary gap is the biggest gap

Most parents focus preparation time on the logic-based question types because they look harder. In practice, the vocabulary questions (Group A) account for more lost marks than any other group. Building word knowledge through daily reading is the highest-return preparation activity available.

02 Verbal Reasoning

All 21 Question Types with Examples

8 min read · Section 02 of 06

These are the 21 standard question types used by GL Assessment. Recognising the type within the first few seconds of reading a question is one of the most important speed skills to develop.

WORD AND MEANING QUESTIONS		
No.	**Question Type**	**What it tests**
1	**Insert a Letter**	Find the single letter that completes the first word and starts the second.
2	**Two Odd Ones Out**	Find the two words that do not belong with the other three.
4	**Closest Meaning**	Find one word from each of two groups that are closest in meaning (synonyms).
10	**Word Connections**	Complete an analogy: Start is to begin as end is to...
12	**Compound Words**	Join one word from group A to one word from group B to make a compound word.
13	**Make a Word**	Find the middle word that connects the outer words using a shared letter pattern.
16	**Opposite Meaning**	Find one word from each group that are opposite in meaning (antonyms).
20	**Complete the Word**	Complete the third word pair using the same spelling pattern as the first two.
21	**Same Meaning**	Find one word that fits meaningfully into two different sentences or word pairs.

CODE AND LETTER QUESTIONS		
No.	**Question Type**	**What it tests**
3	**Alphabet Codes**	Decode a word encoded with an alphabet shift and apply the same shift to a new word.
5	**Hidden Word**	Find the four-letter word buried across two adjacent words in a sentence.
6	**Missing Word**	Identify the three-letter word removed from the middle of a longer word.
8	**Move a Letter**	Move one letter from the first word to the second to create two new valid words.
9	**Letter Series**	Identify the rule in a sequence of letter pairs and find the next pair.
14	**Letter Connections**	Apply the same relationship between letter pairs to find the missing pair.

19	**Word-Number Codes**	Decipher which number stands for which letter by comparing coded words.

LOGIC AND NUMBER QUESTIONS		
No.	**Question Type**	**What it tests**
7	**Letters for Numbers**	Assign letters their numerical values and solve the resulting equation.
11	**Number Series**	Identify the mathematical rule in a sequence of numbers and find the next term.
15	**Reading Information**	Read a paragraph of facts and identify which statement must be true.
17	**Complete the Sum**	Find the missing number that balances both sides of an equation.
18	**Related Numbers**	Find the missing middle number based on the relationship between the outer numbers.

Worked Examples

The examples below cover one question from each group. In every case, the answer is reached by applying a method, not by guessing.

Type 3: Alphabet Code

If LUCK is coded as JSAI, what is the code for GOOD?

Answer: EMMB

L becomes J (back 2), U becomes S (back 2), C becomes A (back 2), K becomes I (back 2). Apply the same shift of minus 2 to each letter in GOOD: G becomes E, O becomes M, O becomes M, D becomes B.

Type 5: Hidden Word

The dog was frightened by the noise.

Answer: then

Slide a window of four letters across the gaps between words: '...by t-h-e-n-oise...' The word 'then' is hidden spanning the word 'the' and the start of 'noise'.

Type 8: Move a Letter

Move one letter from BEACON to VENT to make two new words.

Answer: beacon minus e gives bacon, vent plus e gives event

Remove the letter E from BEACON to get BACON (a valid word). Place the E at the start of VENT to get EVENT (a valid word). This is the only letter that works for both.

Type 7: Letters for Numbers

If A = 5, B = 14, C = 12, D = 3, E = 11. What is A + C minus D?

Answer: B (because 5 + 12 minus 3 = 14)

Substitute the values: 5 + 12 = 17, then 17 minus 3 = 14. Look up which letter equals 14: that is B. Always convert back to a letter at the end.

Type 2: Two Odd Ones Out

red, white, flag, blue, pole

Answer: flag, pole

Red, white, and blue are all colours. Flag and pole do not belong to the colour category. The category is colours of the Union Jack or simply primary/common colours. Flag and pole are objects, not colours.

03 Verbal Reasoning

Eight Strategies That Save Time

5 min read · Section 03 of 06

These strategies are not generic exam tips. Each one addresses a specific, recurring mistake that costs marks in VR papers. Practise applying them deliberately until they become automatic.

Write out the full alphabet at the start

Before answering a single question, write A through to Z across the top of your answer sheet or scrap paper. Counting alphabet shifts in your head leads to errors. Counting along a written alphabet line is fast and almost never wrong. This takes fifteen seconds and saves minutes.

The alphabet is a loop

After Z comes A again. If a code shifts letters forward and you reach Z, the next letter is A. If a code shifts backward and you are at A, the previous letter is Z. Students who do not know this will always get alphabet codes near the end of the alphabet wrong.

Mark and move: every question is worth one mark

There are no two-mark questions in GL VR. If a question is not yielding an answer within 45 seconds, write your best guess, put a small circle around the question number, and move on. Return to circled questions only once you have answered everything else. Easy marks at the end of the paper are worth exactly the same as hard marks in the middle.

Eliminate before you guess

When stuck, cross out the options that are definitely wrong first. Even eliminating one option changes a one-in-five guess into a one-in-four guess. Eliminating two or three options makes the remaining choice very likely to be correct.

The Window Method for Hidden Words

Do not read the sentence normally. Instead, slowly slide an imaginary four-letter window across the boundary between every pair of adjacent words. Read the last two or three letters of one word together with the first two or three letters of the next. This is the only reliable method. Reading the sentence for meaning first will cause you to miss the hidden word.

Apply BIDMAS to all number questions

For any equation involving letters and numbers, always follow the order of operations: Brackets first, then Indices, then Division and Multiplication (left to right), then Addition and Subtraction (left to right). Doing addition before multiplication is the single most common arithmetic error in this section.

Underline the key instruction word before you start

Questions often ask for opposite, similar, four letters, or three letters. Underlining this word before reading the rest of the question takes two seconds and prevents the most common mistake in VR: correctly solving the wrong task.

Check all five options, not just the first that looks right

The first-choice trap is one of the most reliable mark-losers in VR. A question may have an option that looks correct on a first scan but is beaten by a better option further down the list. Always scan all five before committing.

04 Verbal Reasoning

Common Traps and How to Avoid Them

4 min read · Section 04 of 06

These traps are deliberately built into the questions by the test designers. They are not accidents. Knowing what to look for is the only defence.

1. THE VOCABULARY GAP

More than half of all Verbal Reasoning errors occur because a student does not know what a word means, not because they cannot do the logic. A student can understand perfectly how synonyms work but still choose the wrong answer if they do not know that 'indolent' means lazy.

The fix is systematic vocabulary building over months, not days. Reading widely, keeping a vocabulary notebook, and learning common prefixes and root words are the three highest-return activities.

2. RED HERRINGS IN ODD ONE OUT QUESTIONS

A word may look like it belongs in the group because it is spelled similarly to the other words, shares a letter pattern, or sounds related. The test deliberately includes these near-misses to catch students who make quick visual judgements.

The defence is to always ask: what is the specific category these words share? Name the category precisely before choosing the odd one out. Vague category thinking ("they all seem similar") leads to wrong answers.

3. INSTRUCTION BLINDNESS

A question asks for a three-letter word. A student finds a four-letter word that fits perfectly and writes it down. The answer is marked wrong. This is not a logic error or a vocabulary error. It is a reading error, and it is entirely preventable.

Always underline the specific instruction (three letters, four letters, two words, a single letter) before attempting the question. This takes two seconds and eliminates the error entirely.

4. TIME SINKS ON LOGIC RIDDLES

A well-constructed logic deduction question can absorb three or four minutes if a student is unsure of the method. This is not three or four marks; it is one mark, and those three minutes contained five or six easy synonym questions at the end of the paper.

The fix is the Mark and Move strategy from Section 03. No single VR question is worth more than one mark. If it is not yielding within 45 seconds, guess, mark it, and come back.

The first-choice trap is the most expensive trap

Picking the first answer that looks acceptable without checking the remaining options is responsible for a surprisingly high proportion of wrong answers in VR papers. The correct answer and an almost-correct distractor are often placed within one or two positions of each other. Always read all five options before choosing.

05 Verbal Reasoning

Word Groups to Memorise

5 min read · Section 05 of 06

Many VR questions test vocabulary that goes beyond everyday language. The categories below appear repeatedly across GL, CEM, and ISEB papers. Building familiarity with these groups before the exam removes the vocabulary barrier from a significant number of questions.

A. ANIMAL VOCABULARY: MALE, FEMALE, AND YOUNG

Questions frequently test whether a student knows the specific names for male, female, and young animals. These are not words that appear in school curriculum. They must be learned deliberately.

- ***Fox:*** dog (male), vixen (female), cub (young)
- ***Deer:*** buck or stag (male), doe or hind (female), fawn (young)
- ***Cattle:*** bull (male), cow (female), calf (young)
- ***Horse:*** stallion (male), mare (female), foal (young)
- ***Goose:*** gander (male), goose (female), gosling (young)
- ***Pig:*** boar (male), sow (female), piglet (young)

B. COLLECTIVE NOUNS

A collective noun is the specific word for a group of things. These appear in Odd One Out questions, analogy questions, and vocabulary questions. Learning the most common ones gives an immediate advantage.

- ***Lions:*** a pride
- ***Crows:*** a murder
- ***Ships:*** a fleet
- ***Wolves:*** a pack
- ***Geese:*** a gaggle (on land) or a skein (in flight)
- ***Fish:*** a shoal or a school
- ***Bees:*** a swarm or a colony
- ***Trees:*** a copse, a grove, or a wood

C. COMPOUND WORD PAIRS TO KNOW

Compound word questions ask students to join one word from group A to one word from group B. The most reliable preparation is building a bank of common compound words so that the correct join is immediately recognisable.

- ***Sun:*** flower, light, set, rise, burn, shine, glasses
- ***Back:*** pack, yard, ground, bone, fire, stage, track
- ***Rain:*** bow, coat, drop, fall, forest, water
- ***Hand:*** some, shake, made, bag, stand, rail, over
- ***Out:*** run, side, door, look, right, standing, put

D. ROOT WORDS AND PREFIXES

Understanding the meaning of common prefixes and root words allows a student to make a confident, educated guess at the meaning of a word they have never seen before. This is a higher-return skill than memorising individual words.

- ***un-, dis-, in-, ir-, im-:*** these all mean not or the opposite of (unhappy, disagree, incorrect, irregular, impossible)
- ***re-:*** means again or back (return, rebuild, reconsider)
- ***pre-:*** means before (prehistoric, preview, prepare)
- ***sub-:*** means under or below (submarine, substandard, subtract)
- ***mis-:*** means wrongly (mistake, mislead, misunderstand)
- ***graph, scribe, script:*** these root words relate to writing (autograph, describe, manuscript)
- ***port:*** means to carry (transport, portable, export)
- ***aud:*** means to hear (audible, audience, auditorium)

Read to build vocabulary, not to test it

Vocabulary is built through repeated exposure to words in context, not through memorising lists. Authors like Arthur Conan Doyle, Charles Dickens, and Rudyard Kipling use the formal, precise vocabulary that appears in 11+ papers. Twenty minutes of reading per day in the six months before the exam will do more for vocabulary than any revision resource.

06 Verbal Reasoning

How to Build the Habit

4 min read · Section 06 of 06

The difference between a score that plateaus and a score that improves is nearly always method, not effort. More practice done badly reinforces bad habits. Structured practice done correctly builds the right ones.

1. SHORT SESSIONS, THREE TIMES A WEEK

The brain consolidates pattern recognition in shorter, repeated sessions more effectively than in long, infrequent ones. Three sessions of 20 to 30 minutes per week produce better results than one session of 90 minutes.

Within each session, focus on one question type only. Do ten questions of that type, then move on. Mixing question types within a session before any single type is secure leads to confusion and slower improvement.

2. THE ERROR AUDIT: TALK THROUGH EVERY MISTAKE

Do not just check whether the answer was right or wrong. For every incorrect answer, say aloud or write down the answer to this specific question: at what point did my reasoning go wrong?

- ***Wrong word meaning:*** add this word to your vocabulary notebook and look it up.
- ***Wrong logic step:*** redo the question from scratch using the correct method, step by step.
- ***Read the task wrong:*** identify the exact word you missed and practise underlining instructions on the next session.
- ***Ran out of time:*** practise the Mark and Move strategy on the next timed session.

Correcting the reasoning is more valuable than correcting the answer. A student who gets the right answer for the wrong reason will fail the next similar question.

3. LEARN THROUGH PLAY WHERE POSSIBLE

Games that build VR skills are some of the most effective preparation tools available, precisely because they do not feel like revision.

- Scrabble and Boggle build vocabulary breadth and the ability to see words within letter groups, directly applicable to Hidden Word and Make a Word questions.
- Crosswords build the ability to hold multiple constraints simultaneously, which is the core skill in Logic Deduction questions.
- Word association games (naming all the words in a category in 60 seconds) build the category-recognition speed required for Odd One Out questions.

The single most important preparation habit

Daily reading of challenging text is the highest-return activity in 11+ VR preparation. It builds vocabulary, improves reading speed, develops a feel for formal register, and makes the comprehension elements of logic questions easier to process. Everything else in this guide is supplementary to it.